THE BRIJ CULTURAL LEADERS FELLOWSHIP

Delivered by Serendipity Arts Foundation

“Nine months. One question. A generation of cultural leaders.”

Programme Bible

Inaugural Cohort · 20 June 2026 – March 2027

Confidential

About the Fellowship

What is a Fellowship?

A fellowship is not a course, a conference, a workshop, or a qualification. It is a sustained period of structured development built around a small, carefully selected group of people who learn with and from each other over time. The cohort is the curriculum as much as the content. The relationships formed are as generative as the sessions. And the work produced belongs entirely to the Fellow — not to any institution, funder, or programme.

Fellowships exist because some kinds of growth cannot be rushed, and cannot happen alone.

What We Are Building

The Brij Cultural Leaders Fellowship is a nine-month leadership development programme for mid-career cultural practitioners and cross-sector professionals across South Asia — the first programme of its kind in the region. It is delivered by Serendipity Arts Foundation.

The Fellowship is built around a single conviction: the most important thing a leader can develop is not a product, but a question. A genuine intellectual inquiry rooted in their own practice, context, and curiosity. Fellows spend nine months developing that question — through structured learning, expert dialogue, peer exchange, and deep reflection. They leave with a Question Proposal: a written articulation of the inquiry they are pursuing and why it matters — a compass for the work ahead.

The Fellowship is part of something larger. SAF is building The Brij — a new typology of cultural centre in Delhi, still emerging. As that work began, something became clear: you cannot build a new kind of cultural institution without the people who know how to lead it. The Fellowship exists to grow those people — not just for The Brij, but for the sector.

Why Serendipity Arts Foundation?

Serendipity Arts Foundation exists at the intersection of arts, education, and institution-building. Its flagship Serendipity Arts Festival — held annually in Goa — is one of South Asia's most significant cultural gatherings, bringing together practitioners, thinkers, and audiences across disciplines and geographies. SAF has spent a decade building the infrastructure, the relationships, and the credibility to hold a programme like this.

The Fellowship is delivered by SAF and culminates at the Festival — where Fellows present their work publicly at the Work in Progress Symposium. The Festival is not a backdrop. It is part of the curriculum.

Application Routes

The Fellowship draws from two entry routes. Both participate in exactly the same programme once selected — the difference is in how Fellows enter and how participation is funded.

Individual Application

Mid-career practitioners and professionals from any discipline — the arts, culture, law, medicine, technology, business, policy, education, journalism, community development, or any adjacent field — with 7+ years of sustained, active practice and a genuine connection to the cultural sector. Individuals apply directly to the Fellowship. Travel for both Goa visits is covered by SAF.

Institutional Nomination

Cultural organisations, foundations, corporate houses, public bodies, universities, media companies, and other institutions may nominate mid-career leaders from within their teams who have a genuine interest in cultural leadership. Nominating institutions can be cultural or non-cultural. The institution funds the Fellow's participation in full, including travel to both Goa visits.

Selection

Across both routes, all applications are reviewed by an independent jury. The jury assesses every application on the same qualities — intellectual curiosity, commitment to collective learning, emerging or demonstrated leadership capacity, and a connection to South Asia — and does so without knowing which route the applicant has come through.

Fees and Bursaries

The programme fee is ₹5,00,000 per Fellow. For individual applicants, this is paid by the Fellow (subject to bursary support). For institutional nominees, this is paid by the nominating institution. All other costs — accommodation, meals, mentor, psychometric assessment, and reading materials — are covered by SAF.

Bursaries are funded by SAF and available to individual applicants only, at three levels: 100%, 75%, or 50% of the programme fee. Bursary decisions are made by the jury after selection decisions are confirmed and are entirely independent of whether a Fellow is selected. Fellows entering through institutional nomination are not eligible for bursaries.

For full details on both application routes, fee structures, bursary allocation, nominating institution obligations, and withdrawal policies, refer to the Application Routes Explained document.

The Fellowship

Programme at a Glance

Duration	Nine months — 20 June 2026 to end of March 2027
Format	Online learning with two compulsory in-person moments in Goa
Online commitment	Maximum 6 hours per week of structured engagement — one live session per week
Cohort size	Approximately 10–15 Fellows — small enough to be genuine community
Opening	Six-day residential in Goa — begins 20 June 2026 — Month 1
In-person moment 2	Three days at the Serendipity Arts Festival, Goa — December 2026 — Month 6
Mentorship	One senior mentor per Fellow — matched after the residential — monthly one-to-ones from Month 2
Final deliverable	Question Proposal — 1,500–2,500 words — submitted end of Month 9

> *"Fellows are researchers and practitioners in the making. The Fellowship holds space for leaders to become leaders."*

The Three Pillars

Every phase of the Fellowship is built around three interlocking pillars that govern how Fellows encounter and absorb material:

Pillar	What it means
Perspectives	Curated framing notes, talks, and conversations that introduce key ideas and provoke reflection. Reading is always optional enrichment — never assessed.
Practice	Guided exercises, journalling prompts, and research tools to develop self-awareness, clarify vision, map networks, and deepen the Question.
Participation	Live sessions, fireside conversations, peer learning circles, and collaborative activities that build dialogue, community, and shared knowledge.

What Fellows Receive

Every Fellow in the programme receives:

- **A six-day residential in Goa** — to open the Fellowship — accommodation, meals, and all programme costs included.

- **A senior mentor** — from the cultural sector, matched individually after the residential, for monthly one-to-one sessions across the full nine months.
- **A psychometric assessment** — completed before arrival, used to deepen self-awareness and inform mentor matching, with coaching sessions from an accredited leadership coach.
- **Six expert-led fireside conversations** — with practitioners, thinkers, and leaders from across the cultural sector and beyond.
- **Weekly live sessions** — with the Course Director across all nine months.
- **Three days at the Serendipity Arts Festival, Goa** — full Festival accreditation, accommodation, and meals included — including the opportunity to present at the Work in Progress Symposium.
- **Curated reading materials** — and access to key frameworks, thinkers, and contemporary discourse across all three phases.
- **A peer cohort** — of exceptional mid-career practitioners and professionals from across South Asia — a network built through nine months of genuine shared work.
- **A Question Proposal** — a developed, written intellectual inquiry that belongs entirely to the Fellow, and that will guide their practice long after the programme closes.

Programme Architecture

Phase I — Self & Context · June–July 2026

The foundational phase focuses on personal reflection, self-awareness, research orientation, and goal setting. The Fellowship opens with the six-day in-person residential on 20 June 2026 — the moment the cohort comes together for the first time. Fellows arrive having completed a short pre-residential preparation pack sent two weeks before. Phase I then continues online through July.

Phase I Learning Objectives — by the end of Phase I, Fellows will have:

- Completed the pre-residential preparation and arrived at the residential with a draft Personal Vision Statement, initial Strengths & Resources Map, and psychometric assessment done
- Built a genuine peer community and established shared norms for learning and collaboration
- Completed a Network and Ecosystem Mapping exercise and begun to understand their position in the cultural field
- Established personalised learning goals to guide the rest of the Fellowship
- Been introduced to the question-led approach and begun formulating an initial research question
- Submitted their Phase I Reflection

Phase II — Ecosystem & Region · August–October 2026

Phase II expands the Fellow's lens to engage critically with the field of arts and culture. All three months are delivered virtually. Each month is anchored by two thematic speaker firesides — short talks followed by open, facilitated conversations. Fellows prepare questions in advance, shaping each session from their own position. The academic content is always in service of the Question: every theme should deepen or complicate the question Fellows are developing.

Phase II Key Themes:

- Culture Theory 101 — key frameworks, thinkers, and contemporary discourse
- Cultural Equity — access, representation, and power structures in arts ecosystems
- Regenerative Practices — environmental and social sustainability in arts and institutions
- Cultural Entrepreneurship — innovation, sustainability, and value creation in culture
- Cultural Diplomacy — soft power, collaboration, and cross-border engagement
- Crisis & Reputation Management — navigating controversy, ethics, and responsibility

Phase III — Leadership & Futures · November 2026–March 2027

The final phase is dedicated to leadership, the Festival experience, and the public articulation of each Fellow's Question. Fellows arrive in Phase III with a clear sense of their question — Phase III is about finding the confidence, rigour, and language to share it with the world. The phase closes not with a finished product but with a Question Proposal: a developed, written articulation of the question Fellows are pursuing and why it matters.

Phase III Key Themes:

- Leadership foundations — values-based, adaptive, and distributed leadership in creative contexts
- Leading creative teams — high-performing teams, psychometric insights, and leadership typologies
- Futures thinking — technology, innovation, and the cultural sector of tomorrow
- Legal and governance frameworks — IP, arts law, institutional compliance
- The Question — from question to abstract to written proposal

How Sessions Work

Virtual Sessions

All virtual sessions follow a half-day format — 3 to 4 hours maximum, including breaks. No back-to-back sessions without a 10-minute break. After 90 minutes of structured engagement, a 20-minute break is required. Sessions close by a designated time to protect social and reflection time.

Session Type	Format
Fireside conversations	Speaker gives 15–20 min talk from own practice. Course Director then facilitates open conversation using questions Fellows submitted in advance. The conversation — not the talk — is the learning.
Peer learning circles	Small groups of 3–4 Fellows in self-facilitated conversation around a prompt or shared exercise. TA circulates to support.
Live working sessions	Full cohort, facilitated by Course Director. Includes check-ins, deliverable sharing, and structured discussion.
Monthly close sessions	End-of-month reflection and transition. Course Director facilitates. Marks the movement from one phase to the next.

The Fireside Format — How Speakers Are Briefed

Every fireside speaker receives a brief from the Programme Manager at least one week before their session. The brief covers: the programme, the cohort size and background, the session format (short talk + facilitated conversation), timing, and the framing question for the session. Speakers are asked not to prepare slides. The conversation is the point.

One week before each fireside — PM sends:

- Speaker brief document (template in Templates folder)
- Framing question for the session
- Short description of the cohort
- Zoom link and technical instructions
- Fellows' submitted questions (sent 3 days before, once collected)

In-Person Moments

There are two in-person moments. Both are compulsory. Both are in Goa. Both are non-negotiable — the Participation Waiver makes this explicit.

Moment	Purpose
June Residential — Month 1	Six days. Full cohort. Community building, personal reflection, strengths work, storytelling, network mapping, vision and mission, mentor introductions, and Phase I deliverables. This is the foundation on which everything else is built.

Serendipity Arts Festival — Month 6	Three days. Full cohort. Festival immersion and the Work in Progress Symposium — Fellows present their Question Abstracts publicly before an audience of peers, mentors, and the wider cultural community attending the Festival.

The Mentor System

Every Fellow is matched with one senior mentor from the cultural sector for the full nine months. The mentor is not a supervisor or a coach — they are a thinking partner. The relationship is the Fellow's to drive. Mentors are matched by the Course Director after the residential, based on preference forms gathered on Day 5 and psychometric results. Monthly one-to-ones of 45–60 minutes run from Month 2 through Month 9, self-scheduled by the Fellow.

For the full mentor system — matching process, mentor expectations, month-by-month rhythm, Fellow guidance, CD monitoring, and rematching procedures — refer to the Mentor System document.

Fellow Deliverables — Full Map

No deliverable is a finished product — each is a stage in the development of the Question. The Course Director reads all reflections and proposals. The PM logs receipt of every submission in the Fellow Tracker.

Deliverable	Notes	When
Pre-Residential — Personal Vision Statement (draft)	First draft — to be revisited throughout. Kept by Fellow.	2 weeks before residential
Pre-Residential — Strengths & Resources Map (begun)	Begun before residential, completed at residential.	2 weeks before residential
Pre-Residential — Psychometric Assessment	Completed before arrival. Results shared with CD for post-residential mentor matching.	2 weeks before residential
Month 1 — Strengths & Resources Map (completed)	Shared in small groups at residential.	Day 2, residential
Month 1 — Storytelling Origin Story (300 words)	Shared with peer partner. Not submitted to team.	Day 3, residential
Month 1 — Communication Style Self-Assessment	Personal reflection tool. Not submitted.	Day 3, residential
Month 1 — Network & Ecosystem Map	Visual exercise — shared with mentor and cohort.	Day 4, residential
Month 1 — Personal Vision & Mission Statement	Drafted at residential. Submitted to Course Director.	Day 5, residential
Month 1 — Personalised Learning Goals	Guides the rest of the Fellowship. Shared with mentor.	Day 5, residential
Month 1 — Phase I Reflection (500–800 words)	Submitted to Course Director. CD reads all.	Day 6, residential
Month 3 — Institutional Audit Notes	Shared within small group. Not submitted to team.	Month 3
Month 4 — Institutional Audit Group Presentation	Small groups present findings to cohort.	Month 4, Week 4
Month 4 — Regenerative Practices Written Response (200–300 words)	Kept for Phase II reflection.	Month 4
Month 5 — Phase II Reflection (500–1,000 words)	Submitted to Course Director. CD reads all.	Month 5, Week 3
Month 6 — Question Statement (draft)	Shared with cohort in peer circle.	Month 6, Week 4
Month 6 — Leadership Style Inventory	Self-reflection tool. Not submitted.	Month 6
Month 6 — Festival Abstract (first draft, 150–200 words)	Underpins Symposium presentation.	Month 6, Week 3

Month 6 — Question Abstract (finalised, 150–200 words)	Presented publicly at Work in Progress Symposium.	Month 6, Week 4+
Month 6 — Festival Field Journal	Observations across 3 Festival days. Not submitted.	Month 6, Festival
Month 7 — Question Proposal (draft)	Shared for peer review. PM logs receipt.	Month 7, Week 3
Month 7 — Peer Feedback on Question Proposals	Written feedback exchanged.	Month 7, Week 3
Month 9 — Final Question Proposal (1,500–2,500 words)	Submitted to Course Director. CD reads all and responds personally.	Month 9, Week 2

PART A

For the Team

Course Director · Programme Manager · Teaching Assistant

For full team role descriptions, responsibilities, month-by-month actions, and communication cadence, refer to the Team Roles & Responsibilities document.

Month-by-Month Running Guide

The running guide below covers all nine months from the programme team's perspective. For each month: what to prepare and send before the month begins, what the team runs each week, and what to track and collect.

Read each month's section before the month begins — not during it.

Pre-Residential Preparation Pack

Sent to all confirmed Fellows on 5 June 2026 · Two weeks before the residential opens

Because the Fellowship opens directly with the residential on 20 June, Fellows receive a preparation pack two weeks in advance. This replaces the online orientation month. The pack is designed to be light — a few hours of self-directed work — so Fellows arrive in Goa already thinking, without front-loading content.

What the team prepares and sends — 5 June 2026

Send / Prepare	Detail	To whom	When
Fellow Welcome Pack	Programme overview, community agreements draft, residential logistics, what to bring	All confirmed Fellows	5 June
Psychometric assessment link	Fellows complete before arrival in Goa — results shared with CD for post-residential mentor matching	All confirmed Fellows	5 June
Personal Vision Statement prompt	Draft prompt — Fellows write a first draft before arrival	All confirmed Fellows	5 June
Strengths & Resources Map (begun)	Worksheet to begin before arrival — completed at the residential	All confirmed Fellows	5 June
Residential logistics pack	Venue, travel information, schedule overview, what to bring	All confirmed Fellows	5 June

CD Note — Pre-Residential Pack:

The tone of the pack matters as much as the content. This is the first thing Fellows receive. It should be warm, direct, and make them feel that something real is beginning.

The framing question to carry into the residential: 'Who am I as a practitioner, and what question am I beginning to ask?'

The psychometric assessment must be completed before arrival — build this in as a clear requirement, not a request. PM chases non-completions by 17 June.

Mentor preference forms are NOT sent in advance. Preferences are gathered on Day 5 of the residential, once Fellows have had five days to understand themselves and what they need. CD confirms all matches in the week after the residential closes.

Month 1: June 2026 — In-Person Residential & Phase I Close

20–25 June 2026 · 6 Days in Goa · Phase I · Self & Context · IN-PERSON

Month 1 is the residential — six days in Goa starting 20 June. This is the Fellowship's opening moment. The team manages arrivals, venue, catering, speakers, all Phase I deliverables, and the Phase I close. Fellows arrive having completed the pre-residential pack: psychometric done, Personal Vision Statement drafted, Strengths Map begun.

Outcome: Fellows leave with a strong cohort bond, all Phase I work completed, mentor preference forms submitted to CD. Mentor matching happens in the week after the residential.

Before Residential — Logistics Checklist

- Venue confirmed: residential capacity for full cohort, programme rooms, outdoor space
- Catering confirmed: breakfast, lunch, dinner, and evening refreshments across all 6 days
- All Fellow travel booked
- Printed Fellow workbooks prepared — one per Fellow (including mentor preference form for Day 5)
- Name cards, logistics information sheets, and welcome packs printed
- Day 2 speaker confirmed in-person — brief sent at least 1 week prior
- Day 4 institution heads confirmed on Zoom — Zoom link sent, brief and framing questions sent 3 days prior
- Buddy pairing list prepared by CD — announced Day 4
- Photography / documentation requirements confirmed
- Accessibility requirements confirmed for all Fellows

Residential Day-by-Day

Day & Theme	What happens
Day 1 — Who Are We?	Arrivals and check-in. Welcome session — Course Director opens the residential. Community agreements built live. Programme overview. Evening: Fellow introductions — each Fellow shares their story in small groups. Psychometric results: first private reflection.
Day 2 — Who Am I?	Strengths & Resources Map completed and shared in small groups. Speaker: Storytelling & Voice (in-person).
Day 3 — How Do I Speak?	Origin story exercise (300 words, shared with peer partner). Communication style self-assessment. Practitioner identity and positionality discussion.
Day 4 — What Do I Know?	Speaker: Institution Heads on Networks (Zoom). Network & Ecosystem Map (~60 min individual). Buddy pairing announced — meet your buddy, share maps.

Day 5 — Where Do I Belong?	Vision & Mission facilitated session. Personalised learning goals set. The Question drafted — first articulation. Mentor preference form completed — Fellows reflect on what kind of thinking partner they need. CD collects forms before close of day.
Day 6 — Where Am I Going?	Phase I Reflection written (500–800 words, individual time). Phase I close — one sentence each: where are you? Departure.

CD Facilitation Note — Opening the Residential (Day 1):

Open by naming what this moment is: the first time this cohort exists as a cohort. Take it seriously — don't rush to content.

Community agreements: build them live. Ask: 'What do you need to be able to speak honestly in this room?' Write responses, reflect back, confirm. Chatham House rules are non-negotiable — name this explicitly.

Fellow introductions: the prompt is not 'tell us what you do' — it is 'tell us why you are here.' The distinction matters.

The Question: 'The question you will spend the next nine months with may not be clear yet. That's fine. The job of the next six days — and the month that follows — is to begin to notice what you are curious about.'

Month 2: July 2026 — Phase I Online Close

July 2026 · Phase I · Self & Context · VIRTUAL

Month 2 follows the residential and closes Phase I online. Fellows are reflecting on and consolidating what emerged during the six days in Goa. The team runs three live sessions: a Post-Residential Debrief, a Mentor Check-In, and the Phase I Close. The Question — first drafted at the residential — is carried forward into Phase II.

Immediate Post-Residential Actions (by end of Week 1)

Action	Detail	Owner	When
CD reviews mentor preference forms	CD reviews all forms collected on Day 5 and confirms matches	CD	Within 3 days of residential close
PM briefs all mentors	PM sends each mentor: programme brief, Fellow's psychometric results, introduction note	PM	By end of Week 1
PM introduces Fellow to mentor	PM sends a warm introduction email to each matched pair	PM	By end of Week 1

Before Month 2 — Send Table

Send / Prepare	Detail	To whom	When
Month 2 Fellow Calendar	Session dates, post-residential reflection prompt, Phase I close details	All Fellows	Day 1
Post-residential reflection prompt	CD-authored prompt — 2–3 questions to guide Fellows' consolidation of the residential	All Fellows	Day 1
Question framing note	Short note introducing the Question framework and how it will develop across Phase II	All Fellows	W2

Weekly Running Plan

Week	What happens & what to prepare
Week 1	Post-Residential Debrief (~75 min). CD facilitates. Fellows share reflections on the residential. What landed? What is still forming? TA takes notes. PM sends mentor introductions by end of this week.
Week 2	Mentor Introduction (~45 min). CD facilitates brief group session: Fellows have now been introduced to their mentor. CD explains what to bring to a first one-to-one. Fellows self-schedule their first session.
Week 3	Question Introduction (~60 min). CD introduces the Question framework formally — how the question will develop over the next five months. Fellows share their first drafted question from Day 5 of the residential.
Week 4	Phase I Close Session (~60 min). CD marks the transition to Phase II. Each Fellow shares: one thing they are carrying forward. PM confirms all Phase I reflections have been submitted.

Month 3: August 2026 — Cultural Ecosystems & Theory

August 2026 · Phase II · Ecosystem & Region · VIRTUAL

Phase II opens. Month 3 has two fireside conversations (Culture Theory 101, Cultural Equity & Access) and the kick-off of the Institutional Audit exercise — small groups assigned by CD, organisations allocated, groups begin working independently.

Before Month 3 — Send Table

Send / Prepare	Detail	To whom	When
Month 3 Fellow Calendar	Session dates, fireside framing notes, Institutional Audit brief	All Fellows	W1, Day 1
Fireside framing note — Culture Theory 101	Short note introducing the session theme	All Fellows	1 week before session
Fellow question form — Culture Theory 101	Fellows submit 1–2 questions before session	All Fellows	3 days before session
Institutional Audit brief	Groups, assigned organisations, timeline, what to produce	All Fellows	W1 or W2
Fireside framing note — Cultural Equity & Access	Short note introducing the session theme	All Fellows	1 week before session
Fellow question form — Cultural Equity & Access	Fellows submit 1–2 questions before session	All Fellows	3 days before session

Fireside Format — How CD Runs Every Fireside Session:

Open by sharing the framing question — not the speaker's bio. The framing question is the invitation to think.

Speaker talk: 15–20 minutes maximum. No slides. CD times and signals at 15 min if needed.

Fireside conversation: CD facilitates using Fellows' submitted questions. Start with the question that opens the widest conversation, not the most specific. Follow the room.

Close: one question back to the speaker — 'What is the question you'd want this cohort to carry?' Then thank and release the speaker before the cohort debrief.

Post-session (within 2 hours): CD sends a short reflection prompt to the cohort based on what emerged in the conversation.

Month 4: September 2026 — Sector Dynamics & Sustainability

September 2026 · Phase II · Ecosystem & Region · VIRTUAL

Two firesides: Regenerative Practices and Cultural Entrepreneurship. Institutional Audit groups compile findings across the month. Week 4: all groups present to the full cohort — CD facilitates presentations and a pattern discussion across all group findings.

Before Month 4 — Send Table

Send / Prepare	Detail	To whom	When
Month 4 Fellow Calendar	Session dates, fireside framing notes, Audit presentation format	All Fellows	W1, Day 1
Audit progress check	PM checks shared docs for each group — flags any that haven't progressed to CD	Audit groups	W2
Presentation format note	Brief note: findings, equity lens analysis, one recommendation	All Fellows	W3
Fireside framing notes × 2	Regenerative Practices and Cultural Entrepreneurship	All Fellows	1 week before each session

Month 5: October 2026 — Diplomacy, Crisis & Phase II Close

October 2026 · Phase II · Ecosystem & Region · VIRTUAL

Two firesides: Cultural Diplomacy and Crisis & Reputation Management. Week 3: Fellows write Phase II Reflection (500–1,000 words) — submitted to CD. Week 4: Phase II close session — CD marks the transition to Phase III.

Before Month 5 — Send Table

Send / Prepare	Detail	To whom	When
Month 5 Fellow Calendar	Session dates, framing notes, Phase II Reflection prompt	All Fellows	W1, Day 1
Phase II Reflection prompt	Structured prompt from CD — 3–4 questions to guide the 500–1,000 word reflection	All Fellows	W2
Fireside framing notes × 2	Cultural Diplomacy and Crisis & Reputation Management	All Fellows	1 week before each session
Phase II close note	CD note framing what Fellows have covered and what Phase III brings	All Fellows	W4, before close session

Month 6: November–December 2026 — Leadership, Festival & Work in Progress Symposium

November–December 2026 (incl. 3 Days in Goa) · Phase III · Leadership & Futures · IN-PERSON + VIRTUAL

Phase III opens. This month combines online leadership content with the second in-person moment: three days at the Serendipity Arts Festival in Goa. Week 1: Fellows draft Question Statement (300–500 words). Week 2: Leadership Foundations live session. Week 3: Festival briefing distributed, abstracts finalised. Festival: Fellows present Question Abstracts publicly at the Work in Progress Symposium. Post-festival: Question Sharing session with the full cohort.

Before Month 6 — Send Table

Send / Prepare	Detail	To whom	When
Month 6 Fellow Calendar	Session dates, Question Statement guidance, Festival briefing	All Fellows	W1, Day 1
Question Statement guidance	The question, why it matters, what the Fellow doesn't yet know	All Fellows	W1
Festival briefing document	What to expect at the Festival, Symposium format, abstract guidance, practical logistics	All Fellows	W2
Festival abstract template	150–200 word abstract format — the written version of the Symposium presentation	All Fellows	W2
All Fellow accreditation confirmed	Confirmed with SAF events team — full Festival access for all Fellows	SAF events team	Before Festival
AV setup confirmed for Symposium venue	Running order finalised with CD	PM / CD	Before Festival
Travel and accommodation for all Fellows	All booked and confirmed	PM	Before Festival

Festival Logistics Checklist

- All Fellow accreditation confirmed with SAF events team
- Festival Symposium slot confirmed: date, time, venue within Festival programme
- All Fellow travel and accommodation booked
- AV setup confirmed for Symposium venue
- Running order finalised — CD has confirmed presentation sequence with all Fellows
- Abstracts received and formatted for any printed Symposium programme

- Celebratory dinner booked for evening of Symposium day
- Photography / documentation arranged

CD Facilitation Note — The Work in Progress Symposium:

Open by framing for the audience — not just for Fellows: 'What you are about to hear are questions, not answers. These practitioners have spent six months developing the rigour to ask the right question. That is the work.'

Introduce each Fellow with one sentence — their name, their track, and one word that captures their Question's territory. Nothing more.

Use a visible timer. Signal at 10 minutes. Wrap at 12.

Facilitate Q&A actively — redirect hostile or premature-answer questions back to the Question.

After each presentation, make one brief observation — not praise, an observation that affirms the significance of what this Fellow is asking.

Close the Symposium, not just the final presentation: 'What you witnessed today is the result of six months of work. These questions will outlast this room.'

Month 7: January 2027 — Post-Festival Reflection, Legal Structures & Peer Review

January 2027 · Phase III · Leadership & Futures · VIRTUAL

Week 1: Post-Festival reflection session — what Fellows witnessed, what it means for the leader's role. Week 2: Legal & Financial Structures session — guest lawyer and finance professional co-presenting. Week 3: Peer review — CD assigns pairs, Fellows exchange Question Proposal drafts and give written feedback. Week 4: Fellows revise proposals.

Before Month 7 — Send Table

Send / Prepare	Detail	To whom	When
Month 7 Fellow Calendar	Session dates, legal session pre-reading, peer review instructions	All Fellows	W1, Day 1
Legal session pre-reading	Not more than 40 pages — circulated 1 week before the session	All Fellows	1 week before W2 session
Peer review pairs	CD assigns pairs — communicated to Fellows at start of W3	All Fellows	W3, Day 1
Proposal submission reminder	Fellows submit draft proposal to PM by W3, Day 1 for peer review	All Fellows	W2, Day 5

Legal Session Format (Week 2, ~90 minutes):

- Lawyer (45 min): Trust/Society/Section 8 structures, registration, governance in India
- Finance professional (30 min): bank accounts, accounting, 80G/12A, FCRA, CSR eligibility
- Q&A (15 min): Fellows ask questions prepared from pre-reading

Pre-reading circulated 1 week prior — not more than 40 pages total

Month 8: February 2027 — Proposal Revision & Submission Preparation

February 2027 · Phase III · Leadership & Futures · VIRTUAL

Month 8 is dedicated to revision and preparation. Fellows have their peer feedback — now they deepen the work. Individual writing time, a final mentor one-to-one, and a submission guidance session with the Course Director before the final proposal goes in during Month 9.

Before Month 8 — Send Table

Send / Prepare	Detail	To whom	When
Month 8 Fellow Calendar	Session dates, submission timeline, revision guidance	All Fellows	W1, Day 1
Submission guidance note	CD note on what a strong final proposal looks like — not a rubric, a frame	All Fellows	W2

Weekly Running Plan

Week	What happens
Week 1	Individual writing time. Fellows revise proposals using peer feedback. Final mentor one-to-one — share revised draft.
Week 2	Submission guidance session with CD — not a rubric, a frame. What a strong final proposal sounds like.
Weeks 3–4	Final revision. Fellows finalise their Question Proposal. Final submission opens in Month 9.

Month 9: March 2027 — Submissions & Programme Close

March 2027 · Phase III · Leadership & Futures · VIRTUAL

The final month. Week 1–2: Final Question Proposal submission (1,500–2,500 words). PM logs receipt, CD sends personal acknowledgements to each Fellow. Week 3–4: Closing Session — alumni transition, certificates issued.

Before Month 9 — Send Table

Send / Prepare	Detail	To whom	When
Month 9 Fellow Calendar	Submission deadline, closing session date, alumni network information	All Fellows	W1, Day 1
Closing session agenda	Brief agenda for the final live session — what happens, what Fellows should bring	All Fellows	3 days before closing session
Alumni network information	What the alumni network is, how to access it, what happens next	All Fellows	W4, closing session day
Certificates	PM prepares certificates — issued at or after the closing session	All Fellows	W4

CD Note — Reading the Final Proposals:

Read as a reader on the journey with the Fellow — not as an examiner. The question is not 'Is this well-written?' but 'Does this reflect what this Fellow has become?'

Look for growth from the residential, not perfection. The quietest Fellows sometimes produce the most honest proposals.

Consider writing a half-page personal response to each Fellow after the programme closes. Not an assessment — a reflection. The kind of thing a mentor would write.

CD Facilitation Note — Closing Session:

This session belongs to the Fellows. The CD's job is to hold the container, not to fill it.

Ask each Fellow to speak one sentence: 'The question I am leaving with.' Not a summary. One sentence.

Name what this cohort has been together. Not what they've produced — who they've been to each other.

Close by naming what comes next: the alumni network, the ongoing relationship, the invitation to stay in each other's work.

PART B

For Fellows

Your guide to the nine months

Welcome to the Brij Fellowship

Nine months. One question. A generation of cultural leaders.

You have been selected for the inaugural cohort of the Brij Cultural Leaders Fellowship — the first programme of its kind in South Asia. What follows is nine months of structured, sustained, relational learning with a small group of exceptional practitioners from across the region.

This programme will ask something of you that most programmes do not: not to produce something, but to develop a question. A genuine exploration of your practice, your sector, and the kind of leader you want to become. That question will travel the nine months with you. It will change — that is the point. And at the end of March, you will submit a Question Proposal: a written articulation of where the question has taken you and why it matters.

You are here because the selection process identified in you the qualities this Fellowship is built for: intellectual curiosity, commitment to collectivity, and leadership capacity — emerging or established. We are glad you are here.

> *"Come with questions, not answers. The nine months will do the rest."*

What to expect

Time commitment	Maximum 6 hours per week of structured engagement during online months. Full days during both in-person moments.
Pre-residential preparation	Two weeks before the residential (from 5 June), you will receive a preparation pack. Complete the psychometric assessment, draft your Personal Vision Statement, and begin your Strengths Map before you arrive in Goa.
Live sessions	One compulsory live session per week on Zoom. Attendance is expected — if you must miss a session, notify the team in advance.
In-person moments	Two compulsory in-person moments in Goa: the June residential (6 days, from 20 June) and the Serendipity Arts Festival (3 days, December). Both are non-negotiable.
Mentorship	Monthly one-to-one with your senior mentor — self-scheduled by you. Your mentor is a thinking partner, not a supervisor.
Deliverables	A series of reflections, exercises, and finally your Question Proposal. None are conventional assessments — all are stages in developing your Question.
The cohort	You will learn as much from your peers as from the programme. Show up for each other.

How We Work Together

The Brij is a community before it is a programme. These agreements were built collectively by the cohort at the opening residential and govern how we work throughout the nine months.

Chatham House Rules

What is said in sessions stays in sessions. You may take away ideas, insights, and reflections — but not attributions. If you want to share something a Fellow said outside the programme, you ask them first.

Non-judgement

You are here to think, not to perform. There are no right answers in this programme — only more honest and more rigorous questions. Bring your uncertainty. Leave your expertise at the door when the room needs it.

Presence

Turn up. Turn up on time. Turn your camera on in live sessions. When you are in the room, be in the room. The cohort is small — your absence is noticed and your presence matters.

Reciprocity

Take from the programme. Give to the programme. Ask for help. Offer help. The cohort's collective intelligence is only as strong as what each person puts into it.

Confidentiality

What Fellows share about their practice, their struggles, and their Questions is shared in trust. Treat it as such. The Question Proposals Fellows produce belong to them — not to their institutions, not to the programme.

Your Question Proposal is yours. No institution — nominating or otherwise — has rights over your intellectual work within this programme. This is guaranteed by the Participation Waiver signed by any nominating institution.

Fellow Coursework — Month by Month

What follows is your month-by-month guide to the programme — what each month contains, what you will be doing, what you will submit, and how to use your mentor well throughout.

Pre-Residential Preparation

Sent 5 June 2026 · Complete before 20 June

Two weeks before the Fellowship opens in Goa, you will receive a preparation pack. It is designed to be light — a few hours of self-directed work — so you arrive already thinking.

Task	What it is
Psychometric assessment	Complete online before arrival. Your results will be shared with the Course Director — they use them, alongside your mentor preference form completed on Day 5 of the residential, to match you with the right mentor.
Personal Vision Statement (first draft)	A draft to bring with you — not finished, not polished. Just honest. You will revisit it throughout the programme.
Strengths & Resources Map (begun)	A worksheet to start before arrival — you will complete it in Goa on Day 2.

What you bring to Goa:

- Psychometric assessment — completed
- Personal Vision Statement — first draft
- Strengths & Resources Map — begun
- The question you are starting to ask — even if it is only a feeling

Month 1: June 2026 — In-Person Residential

20–25 June 2026 · 6 Days in Goa · Phase I · IN-PERSON

The residential is not a lecture programme. It is six days of community, reflection, and deep personal work — the foundation on which the rest of the Fellowship is built. You will leave Goa with a strong cohort bond, a clearer sense of your practice and Question, and all Phase I deliverables completed.

Day & Theme	What happens
Day 1 — Who Are We?	Arrivals, welcome session, community agreements built live, programme overview. Evening: Fellow introductions — each Fellow shares their story in small groups. Psychometric results: first private reflection.
Day 2 — Who Am I?	Strengths & Resources Map completed and shared in small groups. Speaker: Storytelling & Voice (in-person).
Day 3 — How Do I Speak?	Origin story exercise (300 words, shared with peer partner). Communication style self-assessment. Practitioner identity and positionality discussion.
Day 4 — What Do I Know?	Speaker: Institution Heads on Networks (Zoom). Network & Ecosystem Map (~60 min individual). Buddy pairing announced — meet your buddy, share maps.
Day 5 — Where Do I Belong?	Vision & Mission facilitated session. Personalised learning goals set. The Question drafted — your first articulation. Mentor preference form completed — what kind of thinking partner do you need?
Day 6 — Where Am I Going?	Phase I Reflection written (500–800 words, individual time). Phase I close — one sentence each: where are you? Departure.

Month 1 — What you submit or share:

- Strengths & Resources Map (completed) — shared in small groups
- Storytelling Origin Story (300 words) — shared with your peer partner
- Network & Ecosystem Map — shared with cohort
- Personal Vision & Mission Statement — submitted to the Course Director
- Personalised Learning Goals — kept for yourself, shared with your mentor once matched
- Mentor preference form — submitted to Course Director on Day 5
- Phase I Reflection (500–800 words) — submitted to the Course Director

Month 2: July 2026 — Phase I Online Close

July 2026 · Phase I · VIRTUAL

Month 2 follows the residential and closes Phase I online. You are reflecting on and consolidating what the six days in Goa opened up. The sessions this month are shorter and more contemplative — space to let things settle before Phase II begins.

Session	What it contains
Post-Residential Debrief (Week 1)	A facilitated group reflection: what landed? What is still forming? What question emerged from the residential that you want to carry into Phase II? By end of this week, you will be introduced to your mentor by the PM.
Mentor Introduction (Week 2)	CD facilitates a group session on how to use your mentor well. You will have received your mentor introduction — self-schedule your first one-to-one this week.
Question Introduction (Week 3)	Course Director introduces the Question framework formally. You share your first drafted question from Day 5.
Phase I Close (Week 4)	CD marks the transition to Phase II. Each Fellow shares one thing they are carrying forward.

Month 2 — What you submit or share:

- Phase I Reflection (500–800 words) — if not submitted at the residential, due by end of Week 1
- The Question (first draft) — shared in Week 3 session

Month 3: August 2026 — Cultural Ecosystems & Theory

August 2026 · Phase II · VIRTUAL

Phase II opens your lens to the field. Each month is anchored by two fireside conversations — you shape these sessions by submitting questions in advance. Read the framing note before each session. Bring your Question into the room.

Session	What it contains
Fireside 1 — Culture Theory 101	Key frameworks, thinkers, and contemporary discourse. Submit 1–2 questions in advance using the link sent by the team.
Fireside 2 — Cultural Equity & Access	Power, access, and representation in arts ecosystems. Submit 1–2 questions in advance.
Institutional Audit	Small groups (assigned by CD) analyse a cultural organisation through an equity lens. You will meet independently as a group and share findings in Month 4. Brief and group assignment sent by PM.

Month 3 — What you submit or share:

- Institutional Audit notes — shared within your small group (not submitted to team)
- Journal entry on Culture Theory 101 — kept for yourself
- Equity reflection prompt — kept for yourself

Month 4: September 2026 — Sector Dynamics & Sustainability

September 2026 · Phase II · VIRTUAL

Session	What it contains
Fireside 1 — Regenerative Practices	Environmental and social sustainability in arts and institutions. Submit 1–2 questions in advance.
Fireside 2 — Cultural Entrepreneurship	Innovation, sustainability, and value creation in culture. Submit 1–2 questions in advance.
Institutional Audit Presentations	Week 4: your group presents findings to the full cohort. Prepare: what you found, your equity lens analysis, one recommendation. CD facilitates a cross-group pattern discussion.

Month 4 — What you submit or share:

- Regenerative Practices written response (200–300 words) — kept for Phase II reflection
- Institutional Audit Group Presentation — presented to cohort in Week 4
- Early Question notes — informal, kept for yourself

Month 5: October 2026 — Diplomacy, Crisis & Phase II Close

October 2026 · Phase II · VIRTUAL

Session	What it contains
Fireside 1 — Cultural Diplomacy	Soft power, collaboration, and cross-border engagement in the arts. Submit 1–2 questions in advance.
Fireside 2 — Crisis & Reputation Management	Navigating controversy, ethics, and responsibility. Submit 1–2 questions in advance.
Phase II Reflection	Week 3: 500–1,000 words submitted to the Course Director. Use the structured prompt sent by CD. This is your opportunity to reflect on what Phase II has taught you and how it has shaped your Question.
Phase II Close	Week 4: live session with CD and mentors. Marks the transition to Phase III.

Month 5 — What you submit or share:

- Phase II Reflection (500–1,000 words) — submitted to Course Director
- Question Statement — to be drafted in Month 6

Month 6: November–December 2026 — Leadership, Festival & Work in Progress Symposium

November–December 2026 (incl. 3 Days in Goa) · Phase III · IN-PERSON + VIRTUAL

Phase III turns toward leadership and the Festival. This month you bring your Question into the open — first with your mentor, then with the cohort, then with the world at the Work in Progress Symposium in Goa.

Element	What it contains
Question Statement (Week 1)	300–500 words: your question, why it matters, what you don't yet know. Reviewed with mentor, then shared with the cohort.
Leadership Foundations session (Week 2)	Live session on values-based, adaptive, and distributed leadership. Leadership Style Inventory completed.
Festival Preparation (Week 3)	Festival briefing distributed. Abstract guidance sent. You begin drafting your 150–200 word abstract.
Serendipity Arts Festival — Goa (December)	Three days. Festival immersion and the Work in Progress Symposium — you present your Question Abstract publicly.
Post-Festival Debrief	Cohort debrief session after return. What did you witness? What does it mean?

Symposium Presentation Format:

- 10–12 minutes per Fellow — spoken presentation based on your 150–200 word abstract
- Audience Q&A after each presentation — facilitated by Course Director
- Public audience includes peers, mentors, and Festival visitors

This is not an assessment — it is a public act of intellectual generosity

Month 6 — What you submit or share:

- Question Statement (300–500 words) — shared with mentor, then presented to cohort
- Leadership Style Inventory — self-reflection, kept for yourself
- Question Abstract (150–200 words) — finalised before the Festival
- Work in Progress Symposium presentation (10–12 min) — delivered publicly at the Festival
- Festival Field Journal — observations across 3 days, kept for yourself

Month 7: January 2027 — Post-Festival Reflection, Legal Structures & Peer Review

January 2027 · Phase III · VIRTUAL

Session	What it contains
Post-Festival Reflection session (Week 1)	Half-page reflection brought to the session — what you witnessed at the Festival and what it reveals about the leader's role.
Legal & Financial Structures session (Week 2)	Lawyer and finance professional co-presenting on structures for cultural organisations in India. Read the pre-reading circulated 1 week before.
Peer Review (Week 3)	You and your assigned peer partner exchange Question Proposal drafts and give each other structured written feedback. Feedback should be specific, generous, honest, and brief — one page maximum.
Proposal development (Week 4)	Revise your proposal based on peer feedback. Final submission in Month 9.

Month 7 — What you submit or share:

- Post-Festival reflection note (half page) — brought to Week 1 session
- Question Proposal draft — submitted to PM at start of Week 3 for peer review
- Written peer feedback on your partner's proposal — exchanged by end of Week 3

Month 8: February 2027 — Proposal Revision & Submission Preparation

February 2027 · Phase III · VIRTUAL

Month 8 is dedicated to revision and preparation. You have your peer feedback — now you deepen the work. Individual writing time, a final mentor one-to-one, and a submission guidance session with the Course Director before the final proposal goes in during Month 9.

Element	What it contains
Individual writing time (Week 1)	Revise your proposal using peer feedback. Final mentor one-to-one — share your revised draft.
Submission guidance session (Week 2)	Brief session with CD — not a rubric, a frame. What a strong final proposal sounds like.
Final revision (Weeks 3–4)	Finalise your Question Proposal. Final submission opens in Month 9.

Month 8 — What you submit or share:

- Revised Question Proposal — shared with mentor in Week 1 one-to-one

Month 9: March 2027 — Submissions & Programme Close

March 2027 · Phase III · VIRTUAL

The final month. Month 9 is light-touch — the work is yours now. Submit your proposal, then come together as a cohort one last time.

Element	What it contains
Final submission (Weeks 1–2)	Final Question Proposal (1,500–2,500 words) submitted to the programme team. CD sends a personal acknowledgement to each Fellow.
Closing Session (Weeks 3–4)	The programme's final live session. One sentence per Fellow: the question you are leaving with. Alumni transition announced. Certificates issued.

Month 9 — What you submit:

- Final Question Proposal (1,500–2,500 words) — submitted to the Course Director by the deadline in Week 2

Your Mentor

Every Brij Fellow is matched with one senior mentor from the cultural sector for the full nine months. The relationship is yours to drive — your mentor is a thinking partner, not a supervisor. They will challenge you, listen to you, and help you develop your Question. They will not direct it.

Your mentor is confirmed after the residential. On Day 5 in Goa, you will complete a mentor preference form — reflecting on five days of self-discovery to identify what kind of thinking partner you need. The Course Director uses this, alongside your psychometric results, to confirm your match in the week following the residential. You will be introduced to your mentor by the Programme Manager at the start of Month 2.

> *For full guidance on how to use your mentor well, what your mentor commits to, and what to do if the relationship is not working, refer to the Mentor System document.*

The Question

The Question is the spine of the Fellowship. It begins before you arrive in Goa — a feeling, a curiosity, something you have been noticing. It develops through Phase II as you engage with theory, practice, and peer dialogue. It arrives at the Festival as an abstract: a live, public articulation of the question and why it matters. And it closes in March as a developed written proposal.

> *"You are not a product-maker. You are the keeper of a question. It may change. That is the point."*

How the Question Develops

Stage	What it is
Pre-residential — First instinct	Notice what you are curious about. Journal it informally. Don't try to form it yet.
Month 1 (Residential) — First draft	The Question framework is introduced. You draft your first question on Day 5 and share it with your mentor once matched.
Month 2 — Carrying it forward	You share your first drafted question with the cohort. It may be rough. That is fine.
Months 3–5 — Deepening	Phase II themes — theory, equity, entrepreneurship, diplomacy, crisis — should deepen or complicate your question. Let them.
Month 6 — Question Statement	300–500 words: your question, why it matters, what you don't yet know. Shared with the cohort.
Month 6 — Abstract & Symposium	150–200 words: the public version of your question. Presented at the Work in Progress Symposium at the Festival.
Month 7 — Full Proposal draft	1,500–2,500 words: developed with mentor guidance, shared for peer review.
Month 9 — Final submission	Revised and submitted. The end of the nine months — and the beginning of the Question continuing beyond them.

What a strong Question Proposal contains:

- **The question** — stated clearly, genuinely open, not a predetermined answer
- **The context** — why this question matters to your practice and to the sector
- **The gap** — what you don't yet know, and why that matters
- **The journey** — how your thinking has developed across the nine months
- **The next step** — what you intend to do with this question after the Fellowship closes